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BETTING BIG ON STORYTELLING

SAMEER NAIR OF APPLAUSE ENTERTAINMENT IS LOOKING FORWARD TO A PACKED BOUQUET OF SHOWS AND FILMS IN 2026

If you were Sameer Nair, managing director of Applause Entertainment, you'd give yourself a fairly good performance review for 2025. The studio started off with the acclaimed series *Black Warrant* (Netflix), followed it up with another one in *The Hunt: The Rajiv Gandhi Assassination Case* (SonyLIV), had one more successful season of *Criminal Justice* featuring Pankaj Tripathi (JioStar), and delivered a powerful and popular theatrical title in Tamil film *Bison Kaalamaadan*.

Ask Nair what was his biggest takeaway from what was also a prolific year with three more series, and he says, "What it tells me is that the audience is open to variety and is open-minded and welcoming. What they are telling us is that this whole 'this is what audiences want and don't want' is not right. They are like 'tell us a good story and let us decide'."

Unlike most production houses, Applause works on a make-sell model, which implies that it first teams up with the creator and then offers a ready show to streaming platforms to acquire. A risky proposition, it requires much confidence in one's content. Nair clarifies that the company doesn't operate like "an independent maverick activity or universe of its own". "We have a fair idea of what the market and platforms want, what will fly; we do our own legal and vetting," he says. Once the show is renewed for a subsequent season, the streamer's participation increases. "The scope of the show expands, there are more cooks in the kitchen and more riding on it," says Nair. "They [platforms] have data too; some suggestions we agree to, some we don't. After



MAN IN CHARGE Sameer Nair is confident that the OTT wave isn't going anywhere

After a prolific 2025, Nair feels that the audience is open to variety and is open-minded and welcoming

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